

GS Nominalization

WHAT THIS STRUCTURE MEANS

Nominalization is the process of converting verbs and adjectives into nouns — turning 'decide' into 'the decision,' 'fail' into 'the failure of,' 'resistant' into 'resistance.' At ILR 3, nominalization is how speakers operate at an abstract register. It allows you to treat processes and qualities as things that can be analyzed, compared, and argued about. A speaker who can say 'the implementation of this policy requires sustained investment' is operating at a different level than one who says 'when they implement this, they need to invest a lot.'

WHAT TO TRY

- Convert action verbs to noun phrases: decide → the decision to, implement → the implementation of
- Convert adjectives to abstract nouns: effective → the effectiveness of, resistant → resistance to
- Use nominalization to name a process and then analyze it: 'this shift toward... reflects...'
- Refer back to a complex idea with a nominalized summary: 'this reluctance to act suggests...'
- Combine nominalization with hedging: 'the apparent failure of X to address Y indicates...'

SENTENCE STARTERS

- "The failure to address X has resulted in..."
- "Resistance to this approach often reflects an underlying assumption that..."
- "The implementation of this policy requires careful consideration of..."
- "What makes this debate complex is the tension between X and Y."
- "The shift toward X reflects a broader recognition that..."

EXAMPLE IN ACTION

Topic: Should governments mandate corporate environmental reporting?

"The reluctance of many corporations to adopt voluntary reporting standards suggests that the expectation of compliance without enforcement is unrealistic. The introduction of mandatory reporting would not guarantee accuracy, but it creates the conditions for accountability that currently do not exist. The effectiveness of any such framework depends heavily on the quality of the verification mechanisms attached to it. The tension between regulatory burden and transparency is real, but the cost of inaction — in terms of both environmental damage and investor misinformation — may outweigh those concerns."

Bold phrases mark active nominalization — converting processes and qualities into abstract nouns that can be analyzed and argued about.